

Gulf Politics, Under Exam Conditions

Lesson 32 — Essay practice: oil, rivalry, and war

What you will know and be able to do

1

Write a complete, timed essay drawing on everything from Lessons 28–31

2

Apply command-term discipline, structure, historiography, and evaluation together

3

Self-assess against the criteria built since Lesson 1

4

Close Block B5 ready to examine peace processes and political Islam after the Cold War

From rentier stability to two devastating wars

Four lessons have traced how oil wealth built durable Gulf monarchies, gave OPEC real but limited leverage, and left Iraq drowning in war debt that led directly to a second devastating conflict. Today tests whether you can weigh this entire arc together.

A full argument-evaluation essay

“Oil has been a more powerful force for regional instability than for regional stability in the Middle East since 1970.” To what extent do you agree?

A representative Paper 3 style question drawing on Lessons 28–31.

PRACTICE • 40 MIN

Write your complete essay now

Write a full essay in response to today's question, under real time pressure, without looking back at earlier lesson slides until you finish.

- Plan your position and structure before writing a single sentence
- Use specific evidence from at least three of Lessons 28–31
- Integrate at least one genuine historiographical reference
- Reach a real, specific judgement in your conclusion

Checking your own essay

Did you weigh Saudi Arabia's stabilising rentier bargain against the destabilising Iran-Iraq War and Gulf War, both fuelled by oil wealth and disputes? Did you avoid treating 'oil' as a single undifferentiated force, distinguishing its different effects in different contexts? Did your conclusion reach a genuine, specific judgement?

What a strong final judgement sounds like

“Oil wealth has stabilised some Gulf states domestically, as Saudi Arabia's rentier bargain shows, while simultaneously fuelling the disputes and war debts that produced the region's two most devastating conflicts of this period. Its effect depends entirely on whether it is distributed to buy quiescence or fought over directly — oil itself is not inherently stabilising or destabilising.”

What Block B6 covers next

The Gulf War's aftermath opened a new chapter: peace process attempts between Israel and the Palestinians, the rise of political Islam as a regional force, and the path toward the 2003 Iraq War. Block B6 covers this next phase in full.

Block B5 recap

Rentier bargain

Distributing oil wealth to buy political quiescence without representation.

Iran-Iraq War debt

The direct financial link between one war and the next.

1986 oil price collapse

OPEC's internal indiscipline undermining its own market power.

Operation Desert Storm

The coalition campaign that liberated Kuwait in 1991.

What we now understand about this era

From the durable rentier bargain underpinning Gulf monarchies, through OPEC's real but contested market power, to a war debt that led directly from one devastating conflict to another — oil's political effects in this region have never been simply good or bad, stabilising or destabilising, but always dependent on how it was used.

Lesson 33 — The Oslo Accords and their collapse

Next lesson starts Block B6: the 1990s peace process between Israel and the Palestinians — its genuine achievements, and why it ultimately failed to deliver a lasting settlement.